



# What's It To Me?

Politics, in your context.

TECHNICAL BIBLE · INTERNAL EDITION

## How the platform *works*, and how to keep it working.

For Romily, Barny and anyone who helps after them: what the site is, how its pieces fit, where every fact comes from, the rules the code enforces, and the routines that keep it running.

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### Owners

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Lead  
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### Canonical copy

docs/PROJECT.md in  
highlyvisual/voter-app  
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# What is in this book

Read sections 1 and 2 first: they hold the purpose and the rules, and every other section follows from them. The runbooks in section 12 are written to be followed step by step.

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HOW TO READ THE FIGURES

Every count in this book was read from the live database or the repository on 25 September 2026. Counts will move as elections are added and archived; the method for re-reading each one is given where it appears. Nothing here is a secret: keys and passwords are named, never shown.

# The platform on one page

What's It To Me? is a non-partisan UK voter-information site. You give it a postcode and a few facts about your household, in bands. It shows every candidate on your ballot, in ballot-paper order and on identical pages, and quotes what each has published, with the source. Where the numbers allow, it also shows what each one winning would change for a household like yours.

The idea is Romily's: an informed electorate makes better decisions, and the way to inform it is to connect politics to a person's own life without telling them what to think. The site never ranks, scores, matches or recommends. It shows consequences and sources; the voter judges. The test for anything new: could a reader take it as the site preferring one candidate? If so, it is not built.

|                                                                                        |                                                                               |                                                                                         |                                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>26</b><br>elections still to come, polling between 1 October and 5 November 2026    | <b>134</b><br>candidates standing on current ballots, each with the same page | <b>376</b><br>live sourced positions in the ledger (506 rows including superseded ones) | <b>94</b><br>sources: party, candidate and official publications, each dated and linked |
| <b>29</b><br>council pages, each with five topics quoted from the council's own papers | <b>19,273</b><br>serving councillors from 384 councils (Open Council Data)    | <b>40,500</b><br>precomputed tax-and-benefit results (PolicyEngine UK)                  | <b>10</b><br>automatic jobs, daily or weekly, each logged and shown on /status          |

## Who does what

**Romily Johnson**, Founder and Product Lead, owns the project. Questions of direction go to her, through numbered question rounds on the questions site; every answer she has given is logged with its status in `docs/romily/feedback-log.md`.

**Barny Trevelyan-Johnson**, Technical Lead, builds and deploys, and holds every secret. Neither is a member of, works for, or is paid by any party or campaign. The project is self-funded and not-for-profit.

## Where it stands

The first live test is the **Holborn and St Pancras by-election on 8 October 2026**: 15 candidates, 268 sourced positions attached to the ballot. The May 2027 local elections follow. Romily plans to send the site round for feedback after the weekend of 26–27 September, then open a social media account the weekend after.

The code is AGPL-3.0; the text, claims and ledger are CC BY-SA 4.0. The repository is private for now.

### WHERE AI IS AND IS NOT USED

AI helps draft the short summaries and helps research sources; every such row records it in `drafted_by`, and every quotation is checked word for word against the source before it is loaded. No AI runs when a visitor uses the site: every page is built from the ledger and official data.

# The rules the code enforces

These came from Romily at the start (impartial, every fact attributed, no way to manipulate figures, no grounds to say the system prefers anyone) and were turned into constraints the code checks, not just intentions.

## How candidates are shown

- Every candidate gets the **identical template**, in **ballot-paper order** (alphabetical by surname). No other ordering exists anywhere.
- **No ranking, scoring, matching or recommending.** Consequences are shown; the reader judges.
- Colour is neutral. A party's own colour appears only on that party's own panel, and only if set in `parties.colour_hex`. Money figures never carry good/bad colours.
- Photos appear only on a candidate's own page; everywhere else it is name and party (Romily, round five).
- Where a candidate has no record in office, the same neutral line is shown for everyone: "Has not held this office before, so there is no voting record to show." Party positions are the layer every candidate has; a personal record is extra.

## How facts are held

- Every claim is a **verbatim quotation** from a named, dated, linked source. A short summary sits beneath it as a reading aid; the quotation is the record.
- Claims live in an **append-only ledger**. Rows are superseded, never edited or deleted; a Postgres trigger refuses updates and deletes.
- Corrections and withdrawals go through `/review` by a named maintainer and are logged publicly with the reason.
- Publication rests on the source, not on a reviewer (Romily, 18 September 2026).
- Households are described in bands only. Nothing a visitor enters is stored; the full postcode never leaves the lookup.

## The never-build list

From `docs/never-build.md`. Any change touching these is refused at review.

|               |                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Scores        | Match percentages, "agreement" scores, or any per-candidate number a reader could read as better or worse.                                                 |
| Favourites    | Hearts, ticks, saved shortlists, or graphs of them.                                                                                                        |
| Ordering      | Drag-to-rank, sort-by-anything-computed, or any ordering other than the ballot paper's.                                                                    |
| Endorsements  | "Recommended for you", "people like you chose".                                                                                                            |
| Ideology      | Opinion maps, ideology radars, left/right axes, party self-classification questionnaires.                                                                  |
| Weighting     | Colour intensity, badge size or placement that varies with a computed quality; incumbency, coverage volume, poll standing or past result used as a weight. |
| AI at runtime | Any LLM call in a user-facing path, and any LLM call anywhere whose sources are outside the claims ledger.                                                 |
| Tracking      | Storing anything a user entered beyond anonymous daily counts.                                                                                             |
| Valence       | Green/red (or any valence colour) on money figures.                                                                                                        |

# How it fits together

A server-rendered Next.js site on Netlify reads from one Supabase database and calls a handful of public APIs live. Three GitHub workflows keep the database current. Tax-and-benefit results are computed offline and loaded as a table.

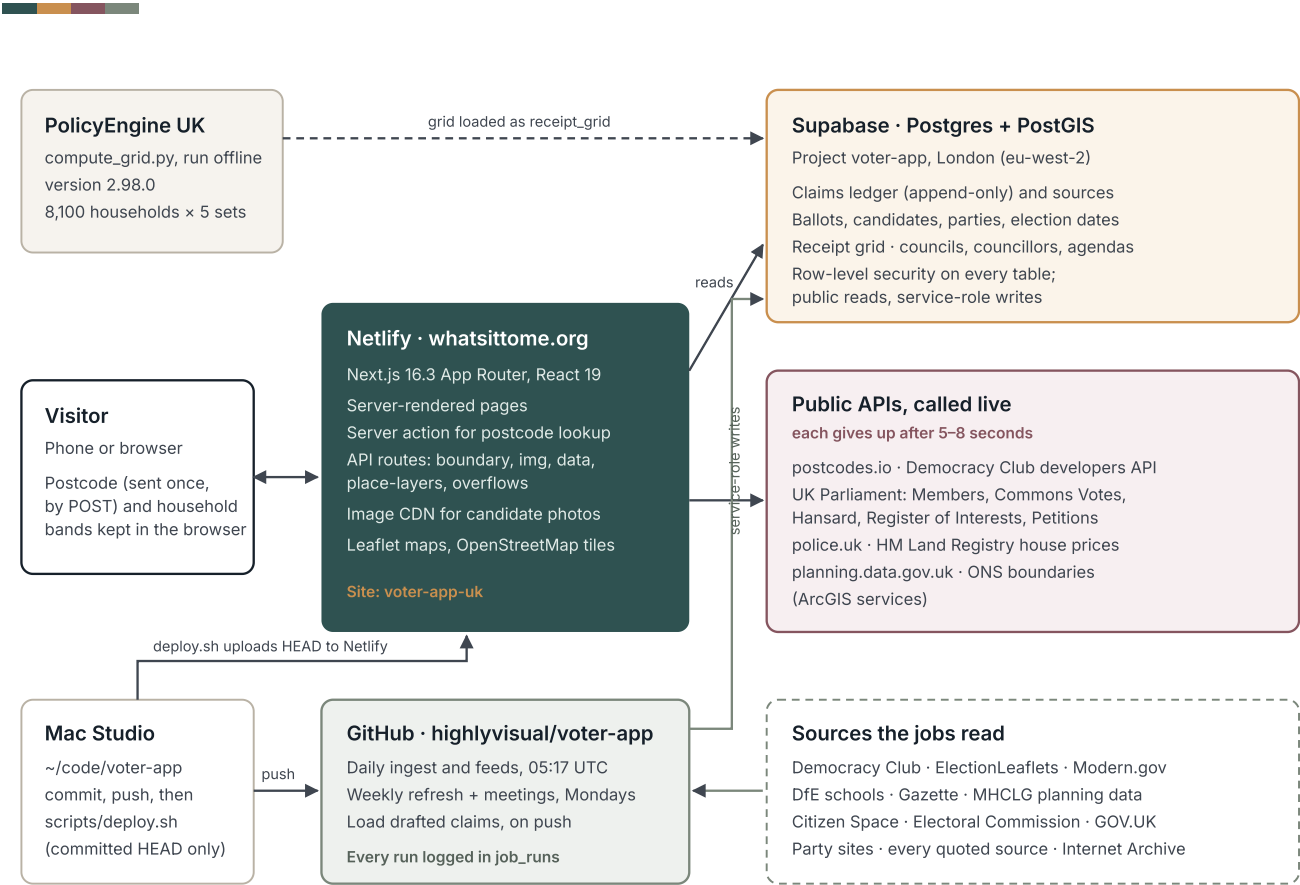


Figure 1. The moving parts. Solid arrows run when a page is served or a job runs; dashed arrows are occasional, manual loads. Section 9 lists every job.

## Where the code lives

| FOLDER      | WHAT IS IN IT                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| app/        | Every page and API route (App Router). Next.js 16.3, React 19, TypeScript. Pages are server components; interactive pieces are client components.                                                                      |
| components/ | About sixty components: candidate cards, maps, the onboarding flow, representatives and wider bodies, deadlines, the feedback widget, display settings.                                                                |
| lib/        | Data access and outside calls: data.ts (Supabase client), democracyclub.ts, parliament.ts, area.ts, place.ts, household.ts (bands and grid keys), councils.json and widerBodies.json, site.ts (name, URL, photo mode). |
| scripts/    | Ingest, claim loading, council meetings, the grid, deploy. scripts/claims/*.json holds drafted claims; scripts/sql/migrations/ holds table DDL.                                                                        |
| docs/       | The handbook ( PROJECT.md ), never-build list, claims style guide, research papers, Romily's rounds and feedback log.                                                                                                  |

# A visit, from postcode to ballot

What happens, in order, when someone uses the site, and which page or file does each step.

- 1. Postcode.** The form posts to the server action in `app/find/actions.ts`, so the postcode never appears in a URL, log or redirect. It checks the format, asks Democracy Club's developers API which ballots cover it (falling back to the candidates API, then to postcodes.io's constituency), and asks postcodes.io for a rounded location. Only the outward code (for example `NW1`) travels on, to draw an approximate circle on the map. The full postcode is then discarded.
- 2. Profile.** `/start` asks which elections you can vote in, then household facts in bands: adults, children, housing, work, income band, age band. Student answers were added on 24 September at Romily's request. Answers stay in the browser.
- 3. Ballot.** `/ballot/[id]` shows every candidate in ballot-paper order, with topics ordered by the profile and the reason shown, then "Explore all topics". Each card carries the same sections, including "Stood before" and "Record in office".
- 4. Depth.** From there: each candidate's own page, a topic across all candidates, a compare grid, the office being elected, the area around the postcode, and a printable notes sheet.
- 5. Practical.** Deadlines, where to vote and accepted ID, from `election_dates` and the Electoral Commission. Then two feedback questions, kept only as daily totals.

## Route map

| ROUTE                                                                                                                    | WHAT IT SHOWS                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>/</code> , <code>/start</code> , <code>/profile</code>                                                             | Home; build and edit the household profile.                                                                      |
| <code>/place</code>                                                                                                      | For postcodes with no election: when you next vote, who represents you at every level, the map, area statistics. |
| <code>/ballot/[id]</code>                                                                                                | The ballot page: every candidate, identical template.                                                            |
| <code>.../candidate/[cid]</code>                                                                                         | One candidate: statement, positions, record, photo.                                                              |
| <code>.../topic/[topic]</code> , <code>.../compare</code>                                                                | One topic across all candidates; candidates across, nine topics down.                                            |
| <code>.../stakes</code> , <code>.../quick</code>                                                                         | What the election could change for you; a two-minute guide.                                                      |
| <code>.../office</code> , <code>.../area</code>                                                                          | What this office controls; the official record for the ground around the postcode.                               |
| <code>.../notes</code> , <code>.../embed</code>                                                                          | Printable notes sheet (browser only); embeddable candidate list.                                                 |
| <code>/council/[slug]</code>                                                                                             | A council's five topics, what it is deciding, who runs it.                                                       |
| <code>/parties</code> , <code>/parties/[ec]</code> , <code>/positions</code>                                             | Every party standing; every position on file.                                                                    |
| <code>/coverage/[id]</code>                                                                                              | How much sourced material exists per party and topic. It measures what we found, not quality.                    |
| <code>/ledger</code> , <code>/ledger/snapshot</code>                                                                     | Every live claim and every change; the full ledger with a SHA-256.                                               |
| <code>/status</code> , <code>/data</code> , <code>/feed.xml</code>                                                       | Data freshness; open data endpoints; an RSS feed of the elections covered.                                       |
| <code>/about/*</code> , <code>/who-we-are</code> , <code>/how-to-vote</code> , <code>/learn</code> , <code>/share</code> | Accuracy, data use, impact, moderation; the founders; how voting works; explainers; share and embed.             |
| <code>/review</code> , <code>/candidates/submit</code>                                                                   | Maintainers' correction console (named passcodes); candidate statement portal (invitation token).                |
| <code>/journey/steps</code> , <code>/journey/flow</code>                                                                 | Two journey prototypes awaiting Romily's choice. Unlinked and not indexed.                                       |

# The data model

One Postgres database, grouped here by job. Tables marked **append-only** have triggers that refuse updates and deletes. Every table has row-level security switched on (the only exception is PostGIS's own `spatial_ref_sys`).



## ELECTIONS

`ballots` (31 not archived, 34 in all): one row per ballot paper, keyed by Democracy Club's `ballot_paper_id`, with level, poll date, area, GSS code, previous contest, cancelled or postponed flags.

`candidates` (161): name, party, verbatim statement to voters, photo and its licence, Parliament member id where matched. `parties` (25): Electoral Commission id, official site, optional colour. `election_dates`: deadlines and notice links. `previous_candidacies` (271), `ward_history` (652), `leaflets` (28).

## CLAIMS LEDGER

`claims` (506 rows, **append-only**): ballot or party, topic, tier, summary, the quote, `applies_if`, status, `supersedes`, `drafted_by`, precision.

`sources` (94): title, URL, publisher, the source's own date, retrieval date, content hash, layer. `change_log` (517, **append-only**). `verifications` (**append-only**). View `current_claims`: the live set (376).

## MONEY

`receipt_grid` (40,500): one row per household cell per reform set, with the household, results and the PolicyEngine version. `party_funding`: Electoral Commission donations, summarised per party.

## PLACE AND COUNCILS

`councillors` (19,273) and `council_control` from Open Council Data. `council_tax_2026` (319), `deprivation_2025` (33,755). `council_agenda_items` (677). `council_pledges`.

## CANDIDATES SPEAKING FOR THEMSELVES

`candidate_invitations` (token hash, channel, status) and `candidate_submissions` (statement, source, check, resulting claim). View `invitation_status`.

## AUTOMATIC LINES, JOB LOG AND WATCHES

`school_changes`, `council_consultations`, `gazette_notices`, `local_plans` (replaced wholesale by their jobs). `job_runs` (every run), `source_checks` (each re-reading of a source), `feed_items`, `release_watch`. Plus `candidates.withdrawn_at` and `sources.archive_url`.

## COUNTS, NEVER PEOPLE

`usage_totals` (lookups per ballot per day), `feedback_totals` (daily answer counts), `feedback_comments` (no identifiers). `resources`: further-reading links.

# The claims ledger

Everything the site says about a party or candidate is a row in one ledger. Rows are never changed, only superseded, and every change is public. That is what lets the site say “no way for figures to be manipulated” and mean it.

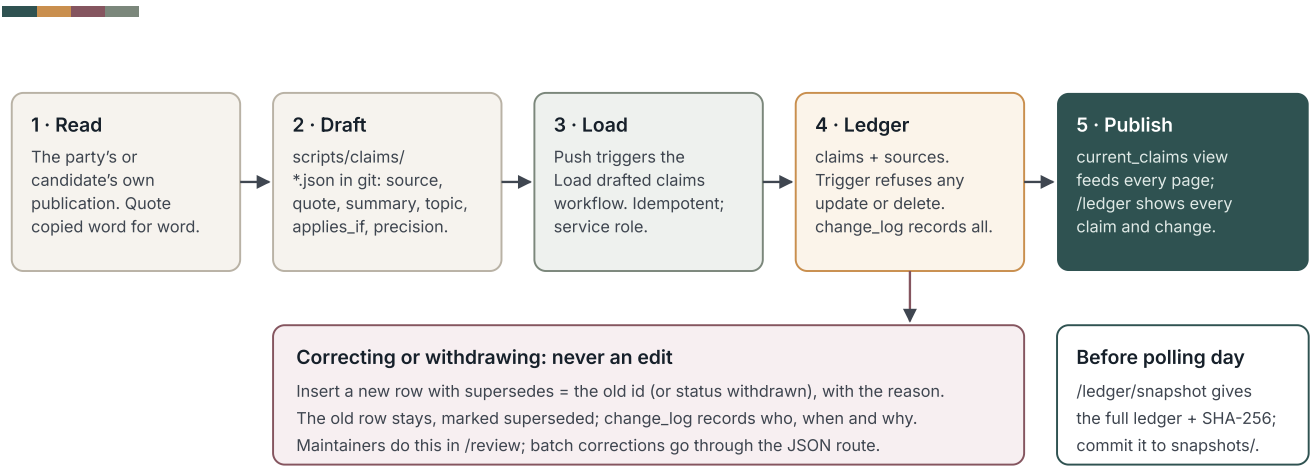


Figure 2. A claim's life. Nothing reaches a page except through the ledger.

## What a claim holds

- **The quotation** ( `source_quote` ): verbatim, the record.
- **The summary** ( `claim_text` ): neutral verbs (“says”, “pledged”, “states”), never “admits”, “boasts”, “fails to”.
- **Who**: a party ( `party_ec_id` ) and/or one ballot and candidate.
- **Topic**: one of nine. One claim per commitment; never bundled.
- **Conditions** in `applies_if` (for example renters, or students), never in the summary. The household profile is matched against these to put the most relevant first; it never hides anything.
- **Re-read every week** by the source watch (section 9), with an Internet Archive copy linked as “Archived copy”. Its first pass re-sourced 24 Liberal Democrat claims to where the words actually are.
- **Sources, primary first**: the party’s or candidate’s own publication, the official record, the statute; a press report only as a flagged interim. The source’s own date and our retrieval date are both shown.
- **Precision**: the threshold rule. A summary may not say “more”, “cut”, “boost”, “invest” without the number, date or object from the source. If the source is vague, it is filed as an aspiration and labelled so.

## Where the 376 live claims come from

| LAYER                          | CLAIMS |
|--------------------------------|--------|
| Manifesto (party publications) | 293    |
| Candidate statement            | 73     |
| Enacted record                 | 9      |
| Third-party analysis           | 1      |
| Campaign leaflet               | 0      |

By topic, the spread runs from 35 (immigration and borders) to 54 (money and cost of living). The layer chips are grey, identical in weight and imply no order. Where they appear, the legend says: candidate statements and leaflets are published as written; we check they are real, not that they are true.

# The money layer

Where a party’s tax or benefit promise is specific enough to model, the site shows what it would change for a household like the visitor’s. The sums are done once, offline, by PolicyEngine UK, and stored as a table the pages look up. Nothing is calculated live.

8,100

household cells: 6 age × 6 income × 3 household × 3 children × 5 housing × 5 work bands

5

reform sets: 2026 baseline, 2024 baseline, and three party policies

2.98.0

PolicyEngine UK version, stored with every row; computed 18 September 2026

| REFORM SET                              | WHAT IT MODELS                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| baseline                                | Current law, 2026.                                                 |
| baseline-2024                           | Law as it stood for the 2024 comparison.                           |
| PP52-2024-employee-ni-6pct              | Conservative 2024: employee National Insurance at 6%.              |
| PP63-2024-ni-upper-earnings-limit       | Green 2024: change to the National Insurance upper earnings limit. |
| PP7931-2026-09-personal-allowance-15000 | Reform UK, September 2026: personal allowance of £15,000.          |

## The assumptions, stated on every calculation

- Income at the band midpoint (over £100k uses £130,000), split 60/40 between adults in a couple. Employed means employment income; self-employed, self-employment income; retired, private pension income.
- Representative ages per band: 17, 21, 30, 42, 57, 70. Children: one child aged 3 (under 5) or 10 (school age).
- Rent: private £15,600 a year for a single adult without children, £21,600 otherwise; social £9,000; owners £0 (mortgage interest not modelled).
- The household is assumed to claim Universal Credit and Child Benefit if entitled. Student status has no modelled effect; “other” households are modelled as one adult.
- Region is London**, because the first covered ballot is in London. This must be extended before money figures are shown for ballots elsewhere.

### HOW A HOUSEHOLD FINDS ITS ROW

`lib/household.ts` folds the fuller set of profile answers into the grid’s bands ( `gridKey` ). The newer answers map onto existing bands: housemates or halls count as “other” households, university halls as “other” housing, a full-time student as “not working”, and studying with a part-time job as “employed”. Unit tests cover the matcher and the key ( `npm test` , 22 passing).

To recompute the baseline: `python scripts/compute_grid.py` writes batches to `scripts/sql/` ; for a past year, `GRID_YEAR=2024` writes `scripts/sql-2024/` . Party policies are defined in `scripts/reform_sets.py` and computed by `scripts/compute_reform_sets.py` . Recompute whenever PolicyEngine changes version or a reform set is added, and record the checksum.

# Councils and wider bodies

Romily’s round-six idea: make councils a major data set, under “What’s happening where you live”. A council gets its own page, separate from any parliamentary ballot, and every layer of government between council and Westminster is shown as a layer, elected bodies first.

## The council page, `/council/[slug]`

1. **Five topics** in fixed order (housing, transport, council tax, environment, education), each quoted from the council’s own publication with link and date. “Nothing found” is said plainly and means nothing found, not nothing happening. District councils say schools belong to the county; counties say housing numbers belong to the districts. Drafts, estimates and government minimums are labelled as such.
2. **What the council is deciding:** every Full Council and Cabinet agenda item from about six months back to three ahead, as the council titled it. Motions are labelled with whoever the agenda names as proposer. A party is added only when the name matches exactly one serving councillor.
3. **Who runs the council:** control and seats by party, next scheduled election, every councillor by ward, and a link to the register of interests (linked, never summarised). No attendance and no allowances, anywhere.

### WHERE THE FACTS LIVE

Council facts are in `lib/councils.json`, in git rather than the ledger, so every change is a reviewable diff. 29 councils as of 25 September, gathered by hand from each council’s site. Council tax Band D comes from MHCLG; control and councillors from Open Council Data.

### MATCHING NAMES

Council names are matched exactly after stripping “Borough”, “District”, “City”, “County”, “Council”. A prefix match was removed on 25 September because it gave Aberdeen City the councillors of Aberdeenshire.

### WIDER BODIES

`lib/widerBodies.json` holds ONS lookups: council to combined authority (106 councils, with mayor flags), the GLA (33 boroughs), and council to fire authority (318). Elected layers (GLA, mayoral combined authorities, Senedd, Scottish Parliament, NI Assembly) join the representatives list. Unelected bodies (NHS integrated care boards, fire and rescue authorities, mayor-less combined authorities, national parks) sit behind “Who else runs things here”, tagged “Not elected”.

## Lines kept current automatically

Beneath the hand-gathered quotations, each topic can carry lines from official registers, marked “Updated automatically” with their source. They add to the council’s own words; they never replace them.

| TOPIC     | SOURCE AND CADENCE                                                                                                         | COVERAGE AND CAVEATS                                                                                      |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Housing   | Local plans, stage, plan period and housing requirement from MHCLG’s planning data platform. Weekly.                       | England. Some entries are old; each shows when the council last updated it. Withdrawn plans are left out. |
| Transport | Traffic and highways orders from The Gazette, last four months. Weekly.                                                    | Mainly London boroughs; most other councils publish orders in local newspapers, which have no open feed.  |
| Education | Proposed and recent openings and closures from DfE’s Get Information about Schools, with the register’s own reason. Daily. | England only. Most closures are academy conversions, which the reason makes plain.                        |

| TOPIC                | SOURCE AND CADENCE                                               | COVERAGE AND CAVEATS                                                                                                  |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Consultations</b> | Open consultations from the council's Citizen Space site. Daily. | Camden, Northumberland and Nottinghamshire today; any council that moves to Citizen Space is picked up automatically. |
| <b>Council tax</b>   | Band D from MHCLG (England).                                     | Loaded yearly; the release watch flags each new edition. Scotland and Wales not yet loaded.                           |

## Meeting papers: which councils can be read

| STATE ON 25 SEPT                 | COUNCILS                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Loading weekly (13)</b>       | Aberdeen City, Bassetlaw, Blackpool, Cotswold, Leeds, Milton Keynes, Newcastle-under-Lyme, North West Leicestershire, Northumberland, South Kesteven, Stroud, Wiltshire, Windsor and Maidenhead |
| <b>Intermittent</b>              | Lambeth: read by some runs and refused by others from GitHub's servers; its last good rows stay until a run succeeds                                                                            |
| <b>Answers, but nothing kept</b> | Argyll and Bute (Full Council now mapped; still returning no meetings)                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Too slow</b>                  | Brighton and Hove, Halton                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Blocks automated readers</b>  | Camden, Carmarthenshire; Stirling disallows in robots.txt, which we respect                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Did not answer</b>            | Flintshire, Mid Devon, East Hertfordshire, Newark and Sherwood                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Other systems</b>             | Highland and Amber Valley (own systems), Nottinghamshire and South Staffordshire (CMIS)                                                                                                         |

Leeds only answers a full browser User-Agent, so the reader sends one for Leeds alone ( `BROWSER_UA` ). Every other council is read with a named User-Agent that gives our contact address.

# Keeping the data current

A machine refreshes anything that comes from an official register or API, and notices anything else changing. It never rewrites a quotation: a claim is only corrected by a person, as a new superseding row. Full detail is in `docs/data-freshness.md`.

| WORKFLOW                                                     | WHEN                                          | JOBS, IN ORDER                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Daily ballot ingest</b><br><code>ingest.yml</code>        | 05:17 UTC daily, and on push of its scripts   | <b>Ballot ingest:</b> asks Democracy Club only for what we do not already hold (everyone again on Mondays); marks candidacies no longer listed as withdrawn, and restores any that reappear; archives ballots the day after polling. Then <b>leaflets</b> , <b>photos</b> (only where missing), <b>schools</b> (DfE register) and <b>consultations</b> (Citizen Space). |
| <b>Council meetings</b><br><code>council-meetings.yml</code> | Mondays 05:40 UTC                             | Full Council and Cabinet agendas and motions from Modern.gov (section 8). Slow councils get two minutes and a retry; hosts that never answer fail after 45 seconds.                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Weekly refresh</b><br><code>weekly-refresh.yml</code>     | Mondays 06:10 UTC                             | <b>Gazette notices</b> , <b>local plans</b> , <b>party publications</b> (new items on party sites and GOV.UK, listed for review), <b>release watch</b> (new editions of official datasets), <b>party funding</b> (rebuilt when the Electoral Commission publishes a quarter), <b>source watch</b> , then the <b>weekly review</b> issue.                                |
| <b>Load drafted claims</b><br><code>load-claims.yml</code>   | On push to <code>scripts/claims/*.json</code> | Loads sources and claims through the service role; idempotent; append-only.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## The source watch

For each of the 232 sources the site quotes, it fetches the page, PDF or Word file, checks every quotation is still present word for word (ignoring case, punctuation and line breaks), records a fingerprint of the text, and keeps an Internet Archive copy: a capture from the last six months if the Archive holds one, otherwise a new one (up to 15 a run, 25 seconds apart). PDFs are read with poppler's `pdftotext`, which keeps words whole. A page with almost no readable text (built by JavaScript, or text inside an image) is reported as “check by hand”, not as a missing quotation. Each run is capped at about 35 minutes and takes the least recently checked sources first.

## How failures reach a person

- Every job writes a row to `job_runs`; `/status` shows each job's last run and flags failed or overdue ones.
- A failed step does not stop the others, but the workflow is marked failed at the end, so GitHub emails the maintainer.
- Each Monday `weekly_review.py` opens one GitHub issue, “Weekly data review” (label `data-review`), listing: jobs failed or overdue; quotations not found; unreadable sources; council facts older than 90 days; new party and GOV.UK publications; new dataset editions; elections with missing candidates or positions; withdrawals.

## Every dataset and how it stays current

| DATA                                     | HOW IT STAYS CURRENT                                           | STILL NEEDS A PERSON                                                    |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Elections, candidates, statements</b> | Daily from Democracy Club; withdrawals and archiving automatic | Statements that refer to another election                               |
| <b>MPs, votes, interests, petitions</b>  | Live from UK Parliament APIs on each page view                 | —                                                                       |
| <b>Party positions (claims)</b>          | Source watch weekly; party publications listed weekly          | Reading new publications; drafting claims; acting on missing quotations |
| <b>Council facts (29 councils)</b>       | Source watch re-reads each fact's link weekly                  | Re-checking facts older than 90 days; broken links                      |

| DATA                                                | HOW IT STAYS CURRENT                                                                        | STILL NEEDS A PERSON                                       |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Schools, consultations, traffic orders, local plans | Automatic (daily or weekly)                                                                 | —                                                          |
| Council meetings and motions                        | Weekly from Modern.gov                                                                      | Councils that block readers or use other systems           |
| Party funding                                       | Rebuilt when a new quarter is published; one person under two donor records is counted once | —                                                          |
| Council tax, deprivation, ONS lookups, councillors  | Release watch flags each new edition                                                        | Reloading (yearly or less; file names change each release) |
| Archived copies                                     | Source watch, weekly                                                                        | —                                                          |

Datasets still loaded by hand: `councillors` and `council_control` (Open Council Data, after each May), `deprivation_2025`, `ward_history`, `council_tax_2026`. Sources, shapes and licences are in `scripts/loaders/README.md`; DDL in `scripts/sql/migrations/`.

## What the meetings reader leaves out

Only mechanical removals, from a public list in the script: section headings; procedural titles (apologies, minutes, declarations of interest, announcements, questions, petitions, appointments, elections of chairs and mayors, forward plans); private items the council withholds; and, following Romily’s rule, anything about attendance or allowances. Nothing is ranked, matched to a ward or chosen by us. Motions are found by the word “motion” in the title or “this council notes/believes/resolves” in the text; the proposer comes from the title or text.

# Infrastructure, secrets and deploys

What runs where, who holds the keys, and the one deploy route that is allowed.

| PIECE          | DETAIL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hosting        | Netlify site <code>voter-app-uk</code> . It shares a \$9-a-month, 1,000-credit pot with 27 other sites; the pot has run out every month since June, and all sites were suspended for about fourteen minutes on 24 September. Each production deploy costs 15 credits (research paper 07). |
| Domains        | <code>whatsittome.org</code> , registered and with DNS at Vercel. <code>hustings.org</code> and <code>thisshitmatters.org</code> redirect to it with the path kept. Mail to <code>hello@whatsittome.org</code> forwards.                                                                  |
| Database       | Supabase project <code>voter-app</code> , ref <code>urufvcutpksjppbjxouc</code> , London, free tier.                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Repository     | <code>github.com/highlyvisual/voter-app</code> , private, AGPL-3.0. Working copy on the Mac Studio at <code>~/code/voter-app</code> ; its remote carries a fine-grained token so a build session can push.                                                                                |
| Scheduled jobs | GitHub Actions on the private repository: about 900 minutes a month against 2,000 free. The weekly review posts its issue with the workflow's own <code>GITHUB_TOKEN</code> ; no extra secret is needed.                                                                                  |
| Democracy Club | Developers API account "What's It To Me?", hobbyist plan: one key, 1,000 requests a day. Used for postcode lookup. It is not accepted by the candidates API.                                                                                                                              |

## Secrets and settings (names only)

| NAME                                                                                                                | WHERE IT IS SET                | WHAT IT IS FOR                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <code>SUPABASE_SERVICE_ROLE_KEY</code>                                                                              | Netlify; GitHub secret         | Writes. Never in the browser.                                                |
| <code>SUPABASE_URL</code>                                                                                           | GitHub secret                  | Jobs' database address.                                                      |
| <code>REVIEWERS</code>                                                                                              | Netlify                        | Named passcodes for <code>/review</code> ( <code>Name:passcode,...</code> ). |
| <code>DEMOCRACY_CLUB_DEVELOPERS_KEY</code>                                                                          | Netlify                        | Postcode lookup.                                                             |
| <code>DEMOCRACY_CLUB_TOKEN</code>                                                                                   | GitHub secret (not yet issued) | Candidates API for the nightly job.                                          |
| <code>NEXT_PUBLIC_SITE_NAME</code> , <code>..._URL</code> , <code>..._TAGLINE</code> , <code>..._PHOTOS_MODE</code> | Netlify (optional)             | Overrides for <code>lib/site.ts</code> .                                     |

Barny alone holds the service-role key, the reviewers' passcodes, the Democracy Club key, the GitHub token, and the Netlify and Vercel accounts.

### THE ONE DEPLOY ROUTE

Commit, push, then run `scripts/deploy.sh "<proxy path>"` on the Mac. The script refuses to run with uncommitted changes, exports `HEAD` with `git archive`, and leaves out snapshots, SQL grids, claim drafts and docs, so the upload is about 3.5 MB instead of 59 MB. The proxy path comes from Netlify's deploy tool and is short-lived.

**Why:** on 24 September a deploy from the working copy overwrote a day's uncommitted work. It was recovered from Netlify's deploy source. Deploys come from committed code only, every time, and because each costs credits, not casually.

# Reliability, privacy and accessibility

The site has to work on polling day, on a cheap phone, for someone who has never used it, without learning anything about them.

## Reliability

- Every server-side call to an outside service gives up after 5–8 seconds, so a slow upstream cannot hold a page past the host's limit and turn it into an error. Each panel already falls back to showing nothing for itself.
- The boundary and image routes answer 504 on a timeout instead of hanging.
- Candidate photos are resized by Netlify's image CDN, so a 56-pixel face costs kilobytes, not a 900 KB original.
- `/status` shows when each data set was last refreshed, lists any election the nightly job missed, and shows every automatic job with its last run: OK, failed or overdue.
- A failed scheduled job fails its workflow, so GitHub emails the maintainer the same day.
- `scripts/check-ballots.py` and `/about/accuracy` test that postcodes resolve to the right ballot (first report: 20 of 20 for Holborn and St Pancras).

## Privacy

- The postcode is sent once, by POST, used to find the ballot and discarded; only the outward code goes further.
- Household answers are bands and stay in the browser. Display settings, notes and topic order use browser storage only.
- What is logged: anonymous daily page counts per election and aggregate bot traffic. No IP addresses, no tracking cookies, no per-visitor records.
- Forms that take input (household form, submission portal, maintenance console) are excluded from crawlers in `robots.txt`.

## Accessibility

Light and dark themes, text size, a high-contrast mode, a light mode for slow connections, read-aloud and a plain-English toggle. Selected answers carry `aria-pressed` and are filled with a tick in both themes. A forced-colours rule keeps borders in Windows high-contrast. Every layout was checked for sideways scrolling at 320 pixels, at 320 pixels with 150% text, and at 1920 pixels. Pages are checked with axe (scripts in `scripts/a11y/`); the most recent smoke run, across 32 pages, found no violations.

## Colour, as a rule

The interface is warm neutrals with one accent, a signature magenta ( `#D6006F` ) chosen because no UK party uses it; it marks interface, never identity. Map legend colours must be clearly different from each other and clearly not party colours, and each legend item explains what it means.

# Runbooks

The routines, in order. Each assumes you are in `~/code/voter-app` on the Mac with a clean working copy.

## Add or correct claims

```
# Read the primary source; copy the quote exactly. Add a file (never edit a loaded one):
scripts/claims/2026-09-25-<what>.json # { "sources": [...], "claims": [...] }
# 3. Commit and push. "Load drafted claims" runs and loads it.
# 4. Check the ledger: current_claims for the ballot, and /ledger.
# A correction is a new claim with "supersedes": <old id> and the reason.
```

## Every Monday: the weekly review (about 30 minutes)

1. Open the issue “Weekly data review”; fix anything under **Jobs** first.
2. **Quotations not found**: open the source and the archived copy. If the words moved, add a superseding claim pointing at where they now are. If they were removed, withdraw the claim in `/review` with the reason.
3. **Could not be read**: open each by hand; replace moved links.
4. **New publications**: read each; draft a claim from the exact words where one states a position on a topic. Check Reform UK’s site by hand.
5. **New editions**: reload the table named. **Facts due**: update `lib/councils.json`.
6. Close the issue with a note of what was done.

## Add a council page

1. Add an entry to `lib/councils.json`: slug, name, GSS code, site, system, the six links (plan, budget, meetings, councillors, interests, consultations), and five facts with summary, verbatim quote, URL, publisher, date and a note. Keep “nothing found” entries, with where you looked.
2. If the council runs Modern.gov and `.../mgWebService.asmx/GetCommittees?LDummy=0` answers, add it to `COUNCILS` in `scripts/fetch_council_meetings.py`. If its Full Council is listed under the council’s own name, add it to `EXTRA_BODIES`.
3. Commit and push (the script change triggers the meetings job), check `council_agenda_items`, then deploy.

## Before a polling day

1. Check deadlines on the ballot page against Democracy Club’s timetable and the working-day rules.
2. Run the ballot accuracy check and read `/status`.
3. Download `/ledger/snapshot` and commit it to `snapshots/` with its SHA-256.
4. Freeze deploys unless something is broken.

## Deploy

```
git status # must be clean
git push
scripts/deploy.sh "<proxy path from Netlify's deploy tool>"
# then smoke-test: every /council/[slug], /, /start, the live ballot pages
```

## Post a question round for Romily

Source in `docs/romily/questions-site/`. Every `<form>` needs `data-netlify="true"` `netlify-honeypot="bot-field"` or answers silently stop arriving. Log answers in `docs/romily/feedback-log.md`.

# Limitations and decisions

Stated plainly, so nobody mistakes an absence for a decision. Figures as at 25 September 2026.

## Decisions waiting on a person

| WHO           | DECISION                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>BARNY</b>  | The opening line (paper 01). Romily's steer: "Politics is personal"; the rest of the copy pass follows it.                                                                                                                          |
| <b>BARNY</b>  | Hosting before 8 October: the shared Netlify pot ran out every month since June and suspended the site on 24 September (paper 07). Options: a separate team or plan, fewer deploys, or another host.                                |
| <b>BARNY</b>  | GitHub Actions minutes: the jobs use about 900 minutes a month against 2,000 free for a private repository. Make the repository public (the AGPL already allows it) or pay for GitHub Pro.                                          |
| <b>BARNY</b>  | Request a Democracy Club candidates-API token (the daily run takes about 16 minutes without one, a few with one) and ask about request limits for polling day; the developers key allows 1,000 lookups a day.                       |
| <b>BARNY</b>  | Free Internet Archive keys: the anonymous service refuses bursts, so only about 15 new captures a week are possible.                                                                                                                |
| <b>BARNY</b>  | Ask Open Council Data about its live feed; by-election changes to councillors appear only on its web pages.                                                                                                                         |
| <b>ROMILY</b> | Should new party publications and candidate statements be drafted into claims automatically (quotation checked word for word by code, summary reviewed by a person afterwards), or stay a list for a person to draft from, as now?  |
| <b>ROMILY</b> | Whether to add official area statistics that can now be automated: council-area emissions (DESNZ), Housing Delivery Test and net additional homes (MHCLG), council housing waiting lists. Neutral, but not the council's own words. |
| <b>ROMILY</b> | Automatic Royal Assent tracking of named Bills for promises (paper 10); works only for the governing party.                                                                                                                         |
| <b>ROMILY</b> | What to rethink in the local-issues rule; journey shape (steps or one page); area statistics and which gap first; transport as a tenth topic; the Democracy Club call slot.                                                         |

## Limitations of the automatic refresh

|                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Blocked sources</b>    | Reform UK's site (29 claims on three pages), Restore Britain's nine policy pages (16 claims) and the Christian Peoples Alliance manifesto PDF (15 claims) refuse automated readers, as do some pages of Wiltshire, Leicestershire, Windsor and Maidenhead, Bassetlaw and Northumberland. They are listed every week for a manual check, so no party is watched less closely than another. |
| <b>Unreadable pages</b>   | Aberdeen's site is built by JavaScript; the Loony party's by-election manifesto is an image; Amber Valley streams its documents. These are flagged "check by hand".                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>Broken links</b>       | Blackpool's environment page and Stirling's housing page now return "not found"; both facts need re-sourcing.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Party publications</b> | Reform UK's site cannot be watched automatically. Labour is watched through its site's post listing and document sitemap, the Conservatives through their sitemap, the Liberal Democrats, Greens, SNP and Plaid Cymru through news feeds, and government policy through GOV.UK.                                                                                                           |
| <b>Traffic orders</b>     | The Gazette carries mainly London boroughs' orders; elsewhere councils use local newspapers, which have no open feed.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Consultations</b>      | Only councils on Citizen Space (3 of 29 today). EngagementHQ gives no dates; Commonplace blocks readers.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Schools</b>            | England only: Wales has no status or dates in its list, and Scotland publishes once a year.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>Council meetings</b>   | 13 councils load; Lambeth intermittently; Brighton and Hove and Halton are too slow; Camden and Carmarthenshire block; Stirling disallows; four hosts do not answer; Argyll and Bute returns no meetings; four councils run other systems.                                                                                                                                                |

|                            |                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Archiving pace</b>      | About 15 new captures a week until keys are set up; sources already captured by the Archive in the last six months are reused straight away. |
| <b>Weekly review issue</b> | Built and tested as a dry run; the first real issue is posted on the first scheduled Monday run.                                             |

## Other known gaps

|                                    |                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Money region</b>                | The grid is computed for London only. Extend the key before showing money figures elsewhere.                      |
| <b>Motion results</b>              | Not in the meeting feed in a consistent form; pages link to minutes.                                              |
| <b>Council tax outside England</b> | Scotland and Wales not yet loaded; both publish machine-readable tables, so this is a build item, not a decision. |
| <b>Photo licences</b>              | Need a human check before any all-or-none photo rule applies.                                                     |
| <b>Election notices</b>            | Notice-of-election links are not filled for every ballot (deadlines themselves are computed).                     |
| <b>Welsh</b>                       | Needs a translator ( <code>docs/welsh.md</code> ).                                                                |
| <b>Cold starts</b>                 | The Holborn and St Pancras page can take about 10 seconds on its first request after a quiet spell, then about 3. |

# The research library

Ten papers in docs/research/ , each fact-checked by a second pass that re-opened the sources. None ranks a candidate or party, and none picks an option for Romily or Barny.

| #  | PAPER                         | WHAT IT FOUND                                                                                                                                                          |
|----|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 01 | Opening line                  | Neutral tools open with a plain task; small wording changes rarely change behaviour. Four lines compared, none picked.                                                 |
| 02 | Promises against records      | Of 50 pledges from the 2024 manifestos: 5 clean pledge-vote pairs, 7 ambiguous, 38 never voted on.                                                                     |
| 03 | The empty record section      | Three patterns in use elsewhere; four layouts set out. Romily chose option 4.                                                                                          |
| 04 | Councillors                   | English councils must record names on budget and council tax votes (since 2014); otherwise no dataset of council votes exists.                                         |
| 05 | The regional level            | No single regional level; what sits between council and Westminster varies by postcode. The site needs its own tables.                                                 |
| 06 | Local-issues rule             | Most councils tested run Modern.gov with an open web service; a draft rule tried on one ward.                                                                          |
| 07 | Running costs                 | The shared Netlify pot runs out monthly; costs set out for four hosts under stated assumptions.                                                                        |
| 08 | Track-record sources          | Commons Votes API, TheyWorkForYou, Modern.gov, ElectionLeaflets, planning.data.gov.uk tested.                                                                          |
| 09 | Sources behind two dashboards | Local Intelligence Hub and the Constituency Dashboards aggregate about 60 official datasets we don't yet use, mostly OGL, all by constituency.                         |
| 10 | Promises, every method        | Only Bill Royal Assent dates and numbered money pledges stay pure fact: 18 of 25 Labour 2024 commitments checked have Royal Assent, 3 are in progress, 4 have no Bill. |

## Brand quick reference

The emblem is profiles and a question mark; the home lockup reads “Politics, in your context.” It is not to be regressed to earlier marks (Barney, 24 September).



Files in `public/brand/`: `lockup`, `logo`, `mark` and `word`, each in light and dark.

### Colour



**Teal**  
#2F5251 · emblem



**Ochre**  
#C98F4E · emblem



**Mauve**  
#85555F · emblem



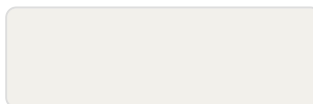
**Sage**  
#7B877B · emblem



**Slate**  
#3D4C5E · headings accent



**Magenta**  
#D6006F · interface only



**Sand**  
#F2F0EB · panels



**Ink**  
#000000 · text on site

On the site, magenta marks interface, never identity, and party colours appear only on a party’s own panel. The emblem colours are for brand material like this book, not for anything that sits next to a candidate.

### Type

#### Newsreader

Headings and reading text. Weights 400–600, with italic for emphasis in headlines.

#### Inter

Interface, labels, tables, metadata. Weights 400–600.

### Voice

Romily’s brief: human, emotional yet factual, never sounding like AI, and always impartial. Plain words; neutral verbs about politicians; say what was checked when something is absent. The site is about the reader’s own life, so it speaks to “you”.

# Glossary

## Fixed vocabularies in the database

| ENUM                   | VALUES                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>topic</b>           | money_and_cost_of_living · housing_and_property · healthcare_and_social_care · education_and_universities · environment_climate_and_energy · immigration_and_borders · crime_policing_and_justice · defence_foreign_affairs_and_eu · equality_and_rights |
| <b>source_layer</b>    | manifesto · enacted_record · candidate_statement · campaign_leaflet · third_party_analysis                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>claim_status</b>    | draft · verified · superseded · withdrawn                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>claim_precision</b> | measurable · aspiration (shown as "Stated aim, no measurable commitment found")                                                                                                                                                                          |

Raw SQL must cast to these types, for example `'housing_and_property'::topic`, or Postgres refuses the insert. Supabase's SQL runner returns only the last statement's result, so run one statement per query when checking.

## Terms

|                                    |                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>applies_if</b>                  | A claim's conditions in structured form (for example renters), matched against the household profile to order what is most relevant first. It never hides a claim. |
| <b>ballot_paper_id</b>             | Democracy Club's id for one ballot paper, for example <code>parl.holborn-and-st-pancras.by.2026-10-08</code> .                                                     |
| <b>CMIS</b>                        | A council meetings system with no open web service like Modern.gov's.                                                                                              |
| <b>current_claims</b>              | The view of live claims: not superseded, not withdrawn.                                                                                                            |
| <b>EC id</b>                       | Electoral Commission party registration number, for example PP52.                                                                                                  |
| <b>GSS code</b>                    | The ONS code for an area (E09000007 is Camden).                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Layer</b>                       | The kind of source a claim comes from: manifesto, enacted record, candidate statement, campaign leaflet, third-party analysis.                                     |
| <b>Modern.gov</b>                  | The meetings system most councils use; many expose a public web service ( <code>mgWebService.aspx</code> ).                                                        |
| <b>OGL</b>                         | Open Government Licence, under which most official statistics are published.                                                                                       |
| <b>PolicyEngine UK</b>             | An open-source tax-and-benefit model of the UK, used offline to compute the receipt grid.                                                                          |
| <b>Precision</b>                   | Measurable (a number, date or object) or aspiration ("Stated aim, no measurable commitment found").                                                                |
| <b>Receipt grid</b>                | The table of precomputed tax-and-benefit results per household cell and reform set.                                                                                |
| <b>Service role</b>                | The Supabase key that can write. Held only in Netlify, GitHub secrets and by Barny.                                                                                |
| <b>SoPN</b>                        | Statement of Persons Nominated: the official list of candidates on a ballot.                                                                                       |
| <b>Supersedes</b>                  | How a claim is corrected: a new row points at the old one, which stays in the ledger.                                                                              |
| <b>Voter Authority Certificate</b> | Free photo ID for voting, for people without other accepted ID.                                                                                                    |



Source and PDF in docs/bible/ in the repository. Update this book when PROJECT.md changes.